Habitat wreckers

The Red List of the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) includes more than 45,000 threatened species. Of these, 80 percent are threatened by the loss or disturbance of habitats that once supported particular species. This destruction can occur as a result of natural causes, such as fire or flood, or, more commonly, through the expansion of agricultural land, timber harvesting, and overgrazing by livestock. Deforestation, in particular, has contributed hugely to habitat loss, with around half of the world's original forests now cleared, mainly for agricultural use.

Some habitats are not destroyed but rather broken up or divided into more isolated units by human interventions, such as building dams or other water diversions. This habitat fragmentation is particularly dangerous for migratory animals because they may no longer be able to find places to feed or rest along their normal routes. Native species and ecosystems are also disrupted by the introduction, accidentally or deliberately, of new species. These invasive species can threaten the food supply or other resources of native species, carry disease, and become a predatory threat. The brown tree snake, for example, was brought accidentally to the island of Guam on a cargo ship, and has caused the extirpation (the extinction of a species in a particular area) of 10 of the island's 11 native bird species.

"It is that range of biodiversity that we must care for—the whole thing—rather than just one or two stars."

David Attenborough

British broadcaster and naturalist
